Special meeting with Prof. Hirokazu Kato

Graduate School of Environmental Studies, Nagoya University · 18 May 2026

Yosuke · Park | Nagoya University, Japan | ~2 hrs discussion | Bus systems expert

KATO'S TOPICS

Public transportation & CO2

Modal shift to public transport is one of the most effective levers for reducing urban CO2 emissions — the foundation of Prof. Kato's research.

Aging society mobility

Works with Transportation Aging Society (~60,000 members) on mobility for elderly and vulnerable populations across Japan.

Law & institutional reform

Directly shaped legislation following a major shuttle bus accident — turning tragedies into systemic, structural reform.

Driver workforce crisis

Japan's driver shortage deepens as the workforce ages. Rebranding "driver" → "instructor" to elevate the profession and attract youth.

> *If you lower the fare, you lower the cost — and the first thing that gets cut is safety. Low fare is not neutral. It is a structural condition for accidents.*

When operators are pressured to lower fares, they reduce vehicle maintenance, driver rest hours, and training quality. The result is not occasional negligence — it is a predictable systemic outcome. Prof. Kato's argument is for **sustainably priced transport**, where costs are distributed fairly between government, operator, and user so safety is never the variable that gets cut.

— Prof. Hirokazu Kato, Nagoya University · 18 May 2026

KEY TAKEAWAYS

TAKEAWAY 01

White-plate flexibility & 9-region governance

TAKEAWAY 02

Driver income below average & the 18-yr pathway

TAKEAWAY 03

Autonomous driving needs years, not 2-week trials

Through the Transport Policy Council, municipalities may now operate buses or ride-sharing using **white-plate vehicles**. Japan is exploring a new organisation divided into **9 regional areas** to monitor and support bus operators — enabling flexible, region-specific responses.

Bus drivers' income has been **far below the prefectural average**. Raising it strengthens depot economics. Prof. Kato proposes a **new education department** — train at 18, work at 19 with driving skills and customer service already in hand.

Current AV demos run only **~2 weeks**. Practical implementation needs **continuous AI training over several years** in realistic traffic. More efficient to train AV systems in taxis first, then transfer to buses.

TAKEAWAY 04

Municipality as operator builds public trust

City-provided buses generate **significantly more public trust** than private operators. Model: municipalities lend vehicles, secure drivers separately — splitting ownership and operation for maximum flexibility and community buy-in.

TAKEAWAY 05

"Transfers" are the key to sustainable transport

Affordable, seamless transfers between buses, railways, and ride-sharing don't just improve one route — they **enhance the viability of the entire system**. Transfers are the missing link in most transport reform agendas.

TAKEAWAY 06

Better conditions + good management = profitability

Combining **higher driver income** with improved business management creates a structure where profitability increases — an economic case for solving the driver shortage, not just a welfare argument.

TAKEAWAY 07

Age barrier blocks new graduate recruitment

Bus and taxi drivers cannot work until a certain age, making it hard to recruit new graduates. The **18-year training pathway** directly closes this gap: real experience before the legal working age.

THAILAND APPLICATIONS

01

Tiered licensing framework

Japan's white/green plate flexibility could inspire conditional licensing for rural community transport in Thailand, lowering barriers while maintaining safety standards.

02

Incident-driven institutional reform

Thailand's bus and van accidents should trigger cost-structure and legal reform — not just enforcement crackdowns.

03

Professionalize & rebrand transport roles

"Driver" → "instructor" framing: elevate social status, attract younger workers, build safer culture. Highly applicable to songthaew and van operators.

04

Minimum fare regulation

Low-fare competition is a structural cause of accidents. Evidence base for Thailand to establish fare floors in the minibus and long-distance bus sectors.

05

City grading / mobility self-evaluation

Prof. Kato's municipal self-assessment system — more points = more policy power — could be adapted as a Thai provincial transport readiness index.

06

Driver income reform & vocational training

Raising driver income to regional average levels and creating an 18-year-old entry pathway could address Thailand's own driver shortage and safety culture gap.

07

Seamless transfer infrastructure

Building affordable, well-connected multi-modal transfer points — bus, rail, ride-share — is the key to making public transport sustainable as a system, not just individual routes.

PHOTOS FROM THE VISIT

Slide: accident site

Jan 2016 — the crash that led to law reform. IMG_9813

Slide: 2006 law reform

Stakeholder framework & plate system. IMG_9814

Slide: rideshare pilot

Japan ride-share in Ise region. IMG_9818

Gift exchange

Thai snacks presented to Prof. Kato. IMG_9856

Discussion

Seminar room Q&A. IMG_9834